

Sloptractions Skill Enhancement: Styleguide, Voice Profiles, and Ablation Testing

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Status: Design approved, pending implementation

Problem

The sloptractions skill produces essays from dialectic outputs, but has several gaps:

1. **Positive constraints are vague and unenforced** — style guide says “be conversational” but doesn’t specify concrete patterns or test for them
2. **Author voice not captured** — generic good-prose advice exists, but Kyle’s specific voice patterns are not documented or enforced
3. **No ablation testing** — components aren’t tested for whether they’re load-bearing
4. **Single-shot generation** — Phase 5 writes once, Phase 6 validates; no iterative refinement
5. **Meso-level density not measured** — Rao’s “pleasurable over summarizable” criterion isn’t tested
6. **High-value dialectic material leaks** — personal grounding and misfits don’t have explicit preservation mechanisms

Solution Overview

Three-layer architecture:

1. **Reference docs** — voice profiles, ablation protocol, Kyle’s pattern map (stable, rarely change)
2. **Phase files** — embed key constraints, point to reference docs for depth
3. **Validation checklist** — comprehensive, tests everything the style guide describes

New Files

1. `reference/ablation-testing.md`

Two types of ablation testing:

Structural Ablation (component-level)

Tests whether components do work or are decorative. For each test:

- Spawn a fresh subagent with no context from siblings
- Provide only the modified text (component removed) and the comprehension question
- Run all tests in parallel (no sequential context bleed)

Component	Remove	Ask Subagent	If Comprehension Survives
Analogy	Strip analogy vocabulary	“Summarize the argument”	Analogy is decorative
Coined term	Replace with placeholder	“What’s the key distinction?”	Term isn’t compressing
Synthesis	Remove synthesis section	“What’s the insight?”	Synthesis is restating
Examples	Remove examples	“Why should I believe this?”	Examples are garnish
Hook	Remove opening	“What problem is being solved?”	Hook isn’t grounding stakes

Meso-Level Ablation (density)

Tests whether text rewards close reading or is all overstory.

Test	Method	Interpretation
Summarize- and- compare	Subagent summarizes in 100 words	What orientation-relevant info is lost?
Pleasurability	“What do you get from close reading that you wouldn’t get from a summary?”	If “not much” → lacks understory

When to use:

- Phases 1-4: Ablation as discovery (learn what you’re actually saying)
- Phase 6: Ablation as validation (verify components are load-bearing)

2. reference/voice-profiles.md

Default Profile: Kyle (see reference/kyle-voice.md)

Alternate Profiles:

Voice	Key Features	Best For
Paul Graham	Deceptively simple, exploratory “I”, short paragraphs	Counterintuitive takes, startup essays
Scott Alexander	Exhaustive thoroughness, constant humor, structural variety	Deep dives, contested topics
Joan Didion	Sparse declarative sentences, omission as power, detached irony	Personal essays, mood over argument
George Orwell	Plain prose, no hedging, concrete over abstract	Polemics, moral clarity
Gwern	Dense citations, quantitative rigor, impersonal, long-form	Technical deep dives, meta-analyses
Matt Levine	Dry wit on technical subjects, absurdist examples	Making boring things interesting

Voice Taxonomy (4 axes):

- Conversational ↔ Authoritative
- Exploratory ↔ Declarative
- Spare ↔ Exhaustive
- Visible author ↔ Receding author

Blending Syntax: “70% Kyle, 30% Gwern density” — apply Kyle’s patterns but increase citation/link density

Selection: Default is Kyle. Override at Phase 5 if essay content suits different voice.

3. reference/kyle-voice.md

Pattern Map:

Pattern	What Kyle Does	Example
Openings	Personal situation → broader significance. Never thesis-first.	"My wife and I often talk about the difficulty of making friends as adults."
Paragraphs	Short-to-medium, liberal subheadings, lists break density	
First person	Frequent natural "I" and "we", author always visibly present	"I've been loosely involved...", "I realized that..."
Questions	Structural transitions, genuine invitations, asks then answers	"Why is this happening now? My general model..."
Hedging	Confident but not arrogant. "My preferred theory atm is..."	
Reader relationship	Fellow traveler thinking out loud, not teacher	
Sentences	Clean, direct, occasional em-dashes, sparing parentheticals	
Technical	Assumes technical reader, explains briefly, links out liberally	
Endings	Questions, invitations to engage, forward-looking – no tidy summaries	"If you're interested, please reach out"
Absent patterns	No throat-clearing, no listicle bookends, no jargon peacocking	

Axis Positioning:

- 70% conversational
- 65% exploratory

- 60% spare
- 75% visible author

Annotated Exemplars: 3-5 passages with margin notes showing patterns in action. (To be extracted from blog corpus during implementation.)

Updates to Existing Files

reference/style-guide.md

Add: Positive Constraints Section

Pattern	Concrete Constraint
Opening	Start 40%+ of essays with personal situation or concrete observation
Questions	Include at least one genuine question you don't know the answer to
First person	"I" should appear in first 100 words
Paragraphs	No paragraph over 5 sentences; at least one 1-2 sentence paragraph per 500 words
Endings	End with question, invitation, or forward-looking statement — not summary
Hedging	Use "I think" / "my sense is" to mark opinion; be declarative on observations

Add: Measurable Metrics Section

Metric	Target
Sentence length variance	Std dev > 8 words
Em-dash usage	1-3 per 1000 words
First-person in first 100 words	Yes
Cliché count	0 from banned list
"Delve/crucial/important to note"	0

Add: AI-ism Detection Section

Patterns to scan for and remove:

- “quiet” as emotional filler
- Unsolicited validation (“You’re not alone”)
- “Bold Header: explanation” list format
- Excessive internal coherence (too smooth)
- Neutral emotional temperature on topics that warrant stance

phases/1-inventory.md

Add: Personal Material Extraction

The dialectic produces structural insight but not personal grounding. Extract or ask:

Constraint	Source
Personal situation opening	Ask: “What’s your personal connection to this topic?”
Concrete observation	Look in context briefing; if abstract, ask for specific example
Genuine question	Check misfit register; ask: “What’s still genuinely unclear to you?”
Lived experience details	Ask: “Any specific names, dates, places, projects?”

Present at checkpoint alongside hook candidates, surprising turn, etc.

Add: Ablation-as-Discovery

Before checkpoint:

- Remove Monk A’s material → is Monk B sufficient alone?
- Remove synthesis → is hook + monks still interesting?

phases/2-analogy.md

Add: Ablation Test for Analogies

For each candidate, sketch argument without analogy vocabulary. If argument still makes sense → analogy is decorative. Only present analogies that fail this test.

phases/3-concepts.md

Add: Ablation Test for Terms

For each coined term, explain key distinction without using the term. If still clear → term is labeling, not compressing. Keep only terms where removal causes loss.

phases/4-outline.md

Add: Personal Material Placement

Map personal material from Phase 1 into arc:

- Personal situation → Hook
- Concrete observation → Hook or Structural Unpacking
- Genuine question → Stakes or throughout
- Lived experience details → wherever they ground abstraction

If Phase 1 didn't surface enough, pause and ask.

phases/5-write.md

Add: Voice Profile Selection

Before writing, confirm voice:

- Default: Kyle voice (see reference/kyle-voice.md)
- Override: Select alternate or blend (see reference/voice-profiles.md)
- Blend syntax: "70% Kyle, 30% Gwern density"

Replace single-shot with: Iterative Refinement Loop

1. Write draft
2. Self-critique: "Where would I skim? Where am I hedging? Where is this generic?"
3. Revise those sections
4. Meso-level ablation: summarize → compare → identify understory loss
5. If loss is low, add density to thin sections
6. Proceed to Phase 6

Add to Validation Checklist:

Test	Method	Fail Action
Voice fidelity	Compare against kyle-voice.md	Line-edit for voice
Cliché scan	Check banned list	Remove/replace
Throat-clearing	Check first paragraph of each section	Cut
AI-ism detection	Scan for known patterns	Add grit
First/last line strength	Read in isolation	Strengthen
Positive constraints	First-person in 100 words? Genuine question? Invitation ending?	Add if missing
Meso-level density	Summarize → compare → measure loss	Add understory if low loss

Add: Structural Ablation Suite

Spawn 5+ parallel fresh subagents, each with one component removed:

- Agent 1: [analogy stripped] → "Summarize the argument"
- Agent 2: [terms replaced] → "What's the key distinction?"
- Agent 3: [synthesis removed] → "What's the insight?"
- Agent 4: [examples removed] → "Why should I believe this?"
- Agent 5: [hook removed] → "What problem is being solved?"
- Agent 6: [full draft] → "Summarize in 100 words"
- Agent 7: [full draft] → "What do you get from close reading vs summary?"

Report results to user. User decides what to strengthen vs. cut.

Architecture Principles

1. **Density through constraint accumulation** — each phase adds tests that eliminate lazy writing modes
2. **Voice as selectable profile** — default (Kyle) with optional overrides/blends at Phase 5
3. **Ablation as discovery and validation** — early phases learn what you're saying; Phase 6 verifies
4. **Decorrelation** — ablation tests use parallel fresh subagents, no context bleed
5. **Meso-level density** — summarize-and-compare test; loss = success
6. **Personal material is required input** — Phase 1 extracts/asks; constraints enforce

Implementation Order

1. Create reference/ablation-testing.md
2. Create reference/voice-profiles.md
3. Create reference/kyle-voice.md (extract exemplars from blog)
4. Update reference/style-guide.md (positive constraints, metrics, AI-isms)
5. Update phases 1-4 (personal material, ablation hooks)
6. Update phase 5 (voice selection, iterative loop)
7. Update phase 6 (expanded checklist, ablation suite)

Open Questions

None — design approved.